



tournament gave fans a chance to catch glimpses of sides that are often hidden from plain sight in their respective continental competitions. Take the case of Cape Verde. The little-known archipelago off the west coast of Africa gained global attention with a quarterfinal finish at the 2023 Africa Cup of Nations.

The team went one better in the CAF qualification campaign for the 2026 World Cup, finishing top of the group ahead of Cameroon. The smallest country by land area to ever participate in the quadrennial event immediately captured the imagination of fans with a gritty stalemate against the reigning European champion, Spain. Goalkeeper Josimar Dias, popularly known as Vozinha, became an overnight internet sensation after pulling off a series of stunning saves against *La Roja*.

The draw against one of the tournament favourites wasn't even the high point of the tournament for Pedro Leitao's (commonly known as

Bubista) side. Yes, it was a solid defensive performance that kept the well-oiled Spanish side at bay. But the more impressive display came in the first knockout round against Argentina.

Cape Verde exhibited immense fearlessness in the lopsided contest against the defending champion, fighting back from a goal down twice before eventually being edged out by an unfortunate own goal. It may have been a Round of 32 elimination, but this feat will no doubt inspire a fresh generation of footballers in the country of just over 530,000.

While Cape Verde emerged as one of Africa's extraordinary stories, another astounding chapter was written by a nation that finally fulfilled its potential.

Egypt, the record AFCON champion, finally navigated its way out of the group stage in just its fourth appearance at the Finals, under the tutelage of head coach Hossam Hassan. In a fairytale

Historic breakthrough: While Messi, Haaland and Mbappe dominated the scoring charts, Salah's lone goal belied his true impact as he led Egypt into its first World Cup knockout stage. AP

return, the Pharaohs' greatest hero of yesteryear took charge of the side in 2024 and converted them into a unit that played with discipline and confidence, even with talisman Mohamed Salah not at his brilliant best.

They went unbeaten in the group stage, holding Belgium and Iran to draws while also convincingly dispatching New Zealand to reach the knockout stage for the first time in their history.

But Egypt's ambitions knew no ceiling. With Hossam and his twin brother, Ibrahim, proving a formidable presence on the sidelines, Egypt showed grit to edge Australia on penalties in the Round of 32, further elevating its legacy.

Its greatest statement, however,